

EUROPE, CENTRAL

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LYING AT THE HEART of Europe on the North European Plain, central Europe consists of four countries: Poland, the Czech Republic, Slovakia, and Hungary. With poor defenses

because of the flat terrain, this historically troubled region has often been invaded by neighbouring powers and its country borders redrawn. At one time or another, French, Germans, and Russians have all dominated the area. After World War II (1939–45), the countries of central Europe became communist states closely tied to the former Soviet Union. Since their independence in the late 1980s, many have struggled to compete on the world market.

Physical features

Most of central Europe lies on the vast North European Plain and is largely flat, rolling farmland, broken by the low Sudeten and Carpathian Mountains in the south. In the north, rivers flow into the Baltic; in the south, they flow into the Danube on its way to the Black Sea.



Tatra Mountains

The Tatra Mountains between Poland and Slovakia are the highest part of the Carpathian Range. Their breathtaking scenery makes them popular with walkers in summer, and in winter the snow-covered peaks attract skiers.



Forests

Poland's Bialowieza National Park is the largest area of woodland in northern Europe. Some woods have survived for thousands of years, but acid rain now threatens them. One quarter of central Europe is forested.



Roman Catholicism

In spite of repeated invasions of the area, and half a century of anti-religious communist rule, Roman Catholicism remains the dominant religion of central Europe. Throughout the region, colourful processions celebrate saints' days and other religious festivals.



Religious procession, Kraków, Poland



Danube River

The Danube is 1,775 miles (2,857 km) long and links Germany and the Rhine River to the Black Sea. It is Europe's greatest waterway and is used for carrying freight and generating hydroelectric power in Slovakia.

Regional climate

Central Europe has a temperate climate with hot summers and cold winters. Winters tend to be milder in the south, except in the Carpathian Mountains and other upland areas where heavy snow falls. The summer months are often the wettest.

